

Overview: Pre-teaching Vocabulary

Pre-teaching vocabulary means introducing key words and their meanings before pupils encounter them in the lesson. By frontloading this vocabulary—during morning registration, with a TA, or the day before—pupils enter the main lesson already familiar with the language. This dramatically reduces cognitive load, allowing them to focus on learning concepts rather than decoding unfamiliar words.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil looks confused when subject-specific terms are used
- Asks "What does that word mean?" repeatedly during explanations
- Stops engaging when new vocabulary is introduced
- Written work avoids using key vocabulary
- Struggles to access texts at age-appropriate level

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Identify key vocabulary

Look at tomorrow's lesson. Pick 3-5 words that are essential for understanding. These are words the pupil won't already know and can't easily guess from context.

Tip: Don't try to pre-teach every unfamiliar word. Focus on the ones that will block understanding if unknown.

2 Create simple definitions

Write a simple, pupil-friendly definition for each word. Avoid using other complex words in the definition. If possible, connect to something the pupil already knows.

Teacher says: "Photosynthesis means how plants make their own food using sunlight."

Tip: Test your definition: would a younger child understand it?

3 Make vocabulary cards

Create simple cards with the word on one side and definition plus picture on the other. Pictures don't need to be fancy—a simple drawing or printed image works.

Tip: Keep cards small enough to fit on the pupil's desk during the lesson as a reference.

4 Find pre-teaching time

Identify when to pre-teach: morning registration, TA time before the lesson, end of day for tomorrow's lesson, or as homework. Even 5 minutes is enough for 3-5 words.

Teacher says: "Before we start, let's look at some words you'll hear in Science today."

5 Teach the words explicitly

Show the word. Say it. Have the pupil say it. Explain the simple definition. Show the picture. Ask the pupil to tell you what it means in their own words.

Teacher says: "This word is chlorophyll. Say it with me: chlor-o-phyll. It's the green stuff inside leaves that catches sunlight. Point to the green in this leaf picture."

6 Quick review before the lesson

At the start of the main lesson, do a 30-second review. Hold up each card briefly. "What does this word mean?" The pupil recalls the definition, reinforcing the memory.

*Teacher says: "Before we start, quick check—what does photosynthesis mean?
Good. What about chlorophyll?"*

English Example: Pre-teaching literary terms for poetry

Year 9 English studying poetry. Pupil working at KS2 level with " Lesson tomorrow.

Identify key words (after school)

Teacher: Select: metaphor, simile, personification. Create cards with simple definitions and example sentences from the poem.

Pupil: N/A - preparation step.

Pre-teach end of day

Teacher: Teacher spends 5 minutes: "Tomorrow we're studying poetry. Here are three important words. A simile compares two things using 'like' or 'as.' The moon was like a silver coin."

Pupil: Listens. Repeats: "Simile uses like or as." Looks at example: "The moon was LIKE a coin—that's the simile."

Send card home

Teacher: Gives vocabulary cards to pupil. "Look at these tonight with someone at home. Try to remember what each word means."

Pupil: Takes cards home. Reviews with parent/carer. Practices saying the words.

Quick check next morning

Teacher: Morning registration: "Remember those poetry words? What's a metaphor?" Praise correct answers. Clarify any confusion.

Pupil: Recalls: "Metaphor says something IS something else." Arrives at English lesson confident with the vocabulary.

Maths Example: Pre-teaching fractions vocabulary

Year 5 Maths lesson on fractions. Pupil working at KS1 level struggles with mathematical language. Lesson is this afternoon.

Identify key words (break time)

Teacher: Select: numerator, denominator, equivalent. Create cards with fraction pictures showing each concept visually.

Pupil: N/A - preparation step.

Pre-teach at lunch (TA)

Teacher: TA shows fraction diagram. "See this number on top? It's called the numerator. Say it: new-mer-ay-tor. It tells us how many pieces we have."

Pupil: Looks at fraction picture. Points to top number. Says "numerator." Counts the shaded pieces.

Link to concrete example

Teacher: TA uses chocolate bar. "If I break this into 4 pieces and eat 3, the denominator is 4—how many pieces total. The numerator is 3—how many I ate."

Pupil: Physically counts pieces. Says: "Denominator is 4 because there are 4 pieces."

Review at lesson start

Teacher: Before Maths: "Remember our fraction words? Point to the numerator. Point to the denominator." Cards on desk for reference.

Pupil: Points correctly. Has vocabulary cards on desk during lesson to check if needed.

Science Example: Pre-teaching photosynthesis vocabulary

Year 7 Science lesson on photosynthesis. Pupil working at KS1 level with limited vocabulary. Lesson is tomorrow afternoon.

Identify key words (day before)

Teacher: Review lesson plan. Select: photosynthesis, chlorophyll, carbon dioxide, oxygen. Create four vocabulary cards with pictures.

Pupil: N/A - preparation step.

Pre-teach with TA (morning registration)

Teacher: TA shows cards one by one. "This is photosynthesis. It means how plants make food from sunlight. Say it: photo-syn-the-sis."

Pupil: Looks at card. Repeats word. Points to picture of plant in sunshine.

Practice definitions

Teacher: TA asks: "What is chlorophyll?" Provides prompts if needed: "It's the green..."

Pupil: Says: "The green stuff that catches sunlight." Matches word cards to picture cards.

Quick review before Science lesson

Teacher: At start of Science: "Before we begin—quick quiz. What does photosynthesis mean?" Shows cards as prompts.

Pupil: Recalls definitions from morning. Feels confident hearing these words in the lesson.